

# CULTIVATE

# The Stepping Stones

*One stone at a time*

Middle Kids Community Space • Ages 6–12 • Part of Cultivate

---

## What The Stepping Stones Is

*The bridge between little and teen*

The Stepping Stones is Cultivate’s community space for kids ages 6–12 — the in-between years that are too often overlooked. Old enough for real curiosity and hands-on projects. Young enough to still need warmth, structure, and nurturing guidance. The Stepping Stones meets kids exactly where they are and helps them find their footing, one stone at a time.

This space sits intentionally between The Sprout Space and The Glade — giving families a complete journey through Cultivate from infancy all the way through the teen years. Kids who grow up in The Stepping Stones arrive at The Glade already knowing who Cultivate is, already confident in who they’re becoming.

---

## The Philosophy

*Curiosity first, confidence always*

The middle childhood years are a unique window. Kids this age are naturally driven by curiosity, eager to make and build and try things. They’re forming their sense of identity, testing their independence, and beginning to understand how they fit into the world around them.

The Stepping Stones is designed to honor all of that — with hands-on exploration, age-appropriate life skills, creative projects, and the kind of warm, structured community that makes kids feel safe enough to take real risks and try new things.

---

## What Happens Here

*Real exploration, real skills, real fun*

### Hands-On Making & Discovery

Kids in The Stepping Stones learn by doing. Building, creating, experimenting, and exploring are the primary languages of this space. Projects are age-appropriate but genuinely challenging — because kids this age rise to meet real expectations when they feel supported.

- Building and basic construction projects
- Simple cooking and kitchen skills
- Art, craft, and creative media exploration
- Science experiments and nature exploration
- Early gardening and understanding where food comes from

### Early Life Skills

The Stepping Stones introduces life skills in ways that are developmentally appropriate and genuinely engaging for middle childhood. These aren’t lectures — they’re experiences.

- Basic home care and tidying — age-appropriate responsibility

- Simple meal preparation and kitchen safety
- Introduction to money, saving, and smart choices
- Communication skills and conflict resolution
- Caring for others — younger children, plants, community spaces

### Community & Identity

Middle childhood is when kids begin asking bigger questions about who they are and where they belong. The Stepping Stones creates space for that exploration — through group projects, collaborative problem-solving, and a community culture that celebrates every kid's unique strengths.

- Group projects that require real teamwork
- Opportunities to lead, teach, and mentor peers
- Creative expression through art, writing, and storytelling
- Community service and caring for the Cultivate campus

### Bridge Programming

As kids in The Stepping Stones approach age 12, they begin to get a taste of what's waiting for them in The Glade. Bridge programming — like occasional joint projects, shared meals, or mentorship connections with Glade teens — makes the transition feel like a natural next chapter rather than an unknown leap.

---

## The Daily Rhythm

*Structured enough to feel safe, open enough to feel free*

Mornings in The Stepping Stones begin with a gentle gathering — a moment to check in, share what's on kids' minds, and set the tone for the day. From there, the day flows between focused project time, skill-building activities, outdoor or creative free exploration, and communal moments like snack and lunch preparation alongside The Glade.

The pace is intentional — not rushed, not rigid. Kids this age thrive when they have enough structure to feel secure and enough freedom to feel like the day is genuinely theirs.

---

## Who Leads The Stepping Stones

*Warm, skilled, and genuinely invested*

The Stepping Stones is led by facilitators who understand middle childhood deeply — the humor, the energy, the occasional drama, and the enormous capacity for growth that defines these years. We prioritize staff and volunteers with backgrounds in education, child development, or youth programming, and we maintain intentional staff-to-child ratios that allow every kid to be truly known.

Teens from The Glade who are interested in working with younger children may also serve as junior mentors in The Stepping Stones — a meaningful leadership opportunity that benefits kids and teens alike.

---

## The Journey

*From sprout to stone to glade*

A child who begins at Cultivate in The Sprout Space and grows through The Stepping Stones into The Glade will have spent years in a community that knows them — their strengths, their quirks, their growth edges, and their story. That kind of continuity is rare, and it's powerful.

The Stepping Stones isn't just a program for middle kids. It's a chapter in a longer story that Cultivate is honored to be part of.

---

*Part of the Cultivate ecosystem* • ***Real Skills for Real Life***

[your email] • [your website or social] • Central Florida